

How to plant

Following tried and tested methods when planting will pay dividends, helping to get plants off to a good start, ensuring they thrive, and improving the long-term survival rate of permanent plants.

PREPARING THE SITE

The best times to plant are in the fall or spring, although container-grown plants can be planted at any time, unless the soil is frozen, waterlogged, or exceptionally dry. Borderline hardy plants are best planted in spring, which allows them to establish a mature root system before winter sets in.

A few weeks before you plan to plant, prepare your soil. Start by removing large stones and rubble, and then tackle the weeds. Dig out by hand perennial weeds, such as dandelions, docks, and bindweed, ensuring you remove the roots. Then hoe off the annual weeds. Leave the bed for a week or two and remove any new weeds that have appeared. If your soil needs improving, dig in composted organic matter and/or grit (*see p.12*).

SHRUBS AND PERENNIALS

Most container-grown shrubs and perennials are planted in the same way. About an hour before planting, give your plant a good soak, either with a watering can, or by placing it in a bucket of water, submerging the pot and waiting until bubbles no longer appear. Then lift it out and let it drain. Meanwhile, dig a hole twice as wide as the pot and a little deeper. Place the plant in the hole and check that it will be at the same depth when planted as it is in its pot. Add or remove soil accordingly, and fork over the bottom of the hole. Mix some slow-release granular fertilizer with the excavated soil, as directed on the package. Remove the plant from its pot, gently massage the root ball, and place it in position. Refill the hole, firming the soil with your hands to remove any air pockets, and water well.



Setting plants out Before planting, set your plants in position on the ground to check that you are happy with their arrangement, facing their best sides forward for an engaging display.



Planting Most plants are planted at the same depth as they were in their pots. After planting, firm the soil well with your hands to remove air pockets. Water well.

